



117 "Tekken"
Review



127 The Original
iMan!



140 Tibet
What?

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Touched By Tech

Anywhere, Anytime AIDS Awareness

How mobile gaming might help the cause of one of the world's biggest epidemics

Samir Makwana

Society has the general mind-set that games are primarily a leisure activity—just for fun, so to speak. But that's been changing, and still is. There are those for whom gaming is more of a religion than leisure: the key-mashers with their games like *Doom* and all. And now we have games being developed for specific purposes, such as for education, skill development, stress reduction, memory improvement, therapy, and more. And they're not just PC-based either, they're available on multiple platforms—consoles, handhelds and mobile phones as well.

There is also development of games for the treatment of specific ailments. Recently, a boy called Ethan Myers—whom we've

spoken of earlier in *Digit*, April 2006—recovered by playing games, after he was declared brain-dead by doctors. A computer game was recently tested for the cure of stress-related illness by doctors at the Royal Free Hospital in London.

The segment gaining most in popularity is mobile games, because these work on devices that most people own, and is something people can play anywhere—the middle of the street, in a train, at work, at home, in a coffee shop. Mobile gaming is spreading like never before in India, and it's no wonder that mobile gaming companies are sprouting faster than tea-stalls outside colleges. And it's not like they're making bad games—some very creative and good-looking 3D games are being created now.

The Mobile Gaming Championship organised by Nokia in the recent past attracted more than 26,000 people across the country, the cash prize being Rs 10 lakh.

With more than 105 million people using mobile phones as of now, the mobile gaming market is set to explode: the number of mobile phone subscribers is expected to exceed 350 million by 2010. Mobile content developers are releasing games with an "international" look and feel.

Social Causes

"I had heard lot about HIV/AIDS on TV. The idea was vague. Now after playing this game, I have become aware about its infection, its prevention and its transmission. I play this game whenever I am free," says Shiv, a household helper with a mobile connection.

—The Hindustan Times

On December 1, 2005, which was National AIDS Prevention Day, New Delhi-based ZMQ Systems unveiled four mobile games. Using edutainment as their platform, ZMQ Software Systems plans on educating people about HIV/AIDS through

